

Photographs ANI



CRITICS WONDER IF KCR IS USING THE TEMPLE PROJECT TO BURNISH HIS OWN IMAGE AS ONE WITH A DIVINE RIGHT TO RULE

NEW HERITAGE The crowds at the Sri Lakshmi Narasimha Swamy Temple on the day of the deity's consecration; (below) KCR taking part in the rites

entrance—is seven storeys and is made of 13,000 tonnes of stone. Its gold plating will call for an estimated 125 kg of the yellow metal. Temple authorities have begun collecting gold donations; the state is expected to make up the shortfall. KCR's ambition is clearly to make Yadadri larger than Tirumala, both in terms of facilities and the number of devotees—even the *laddu*-making machine, capable of rolling out 50,000 sweetmeats an hour.

The temple claims to be the only one in India to have been built entirely out of Krishnasila (black stone), some 250,000 tonnes of which was sourced from Prakasam and Guntur districts. To create a kind of authenticity specific to period structures, the YTDA relied on conventional binding materials like lime and mortar. "Yadadri is a confluence of multiple temple architecture styles found in Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh," says B. Anand Sai, the chief architect. As for KCR, he had only one brief: that the temple be imposing and visible by rail or road on the Hyderabad-Warangal route. Of the entire heritage conglomeration of 2,000 acres, only 250 acres around the hill shrine have been developed so far. The temple town and the appurtenant facilities are works in progress. But a culmination of sorts came with the Maha Kumbha Samprokshana (consecration), which KCR took part in, performing the kalasha pujas and even joining the procession that carried the deity from Balalayam, its makeshift abode during the renovation, to the sanctum sanctorum. Chinna Jeeyar Swamy was again involved in suggesting the consecration rituals, though he himself was strangely absent on March 28.

KCR's desire to position himself as the builder of modern Telangana, as well as the keeper of its traditions and cultural identity, shines through in all these. Ever since he assumed office in 2014, the ruling Telangana Rashtra Samithi chief has been the fountainhead of a grand building spree—personally conceptualising the design and development of his dream projects. First off was the sprawling CM's office-cum-residence Pragati Bhavan in the heart of Hyderabad. Then came the massive Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation Scheme to augment the state's irrigation facilities at a cost of Rs 1 lakh crore. He had also hoped to build a swanky state secretariat in the Secunderabad cantonment, but wrangles with the Union defence ministry over land forced him back to Hyderabad—he had the existing 132-year-old, Nizam-era secretariat complex pulled down for a grand structure that's in its final stages. Another dream venture—a new legislature atop a heritage building—had to be aborted following an outcry by conservation activists and the courts.

Still, Yadadri will be the showpiece amongst all these—hence his participation from start to finish. "As engineer, sculptor and scholar, all credit goes to him...KCR's name will remain forever, as long as the Sun and Moon exist," declared cabinet colleague Jagdish Reddy, mouthing words of veneration more associated with erstwhile royalty. YTDA vice-chairman G. Kishen Rao, too, says "the CM's vision has become a reality because of the keen interest he took at all stages of the project with regular visits and reviews". State BJP vice-president D.K. Aruna strikes a sour note amid all the adulation. "KCR has been treating the temple as if it were his personal property," he says. "By changing the name to Yadadri, he has trampled on the sentiments of devout Hindus. He will pay the price for it." But people seem spellbound. On Ugadi, the Telugu new year day on April 2, over 30,000 people flocked to see KCR's vision in gold and granite. The CM's cabinet colleagues now want to take up temple reconstruction elsewhere in the state—whatever critics say, power and prayer seem to be like lime and mortar. ■